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David Murray

Saxophonist/bass clarinetist David Murray was born in Oakland, California on February 19, 1955. He was an original member of the World Saxophone Quartet and has recorded prolifically with his own ensembles. David's highly emotional playing reflects all of the recognized jazz styles and he incorporates influences from African and Latin music in his recent compositions.

David was interviewed in Clinton, New York on September 18, 2003 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are at Hamilton College and I'm extremely pleased to have David Murray with me for the Jazz Archive.

DM: Well I'm pleased to be here, Monk, because this is where I want to be, with all the greats.

MR: Thank you. I scarcely know where to start with you because you've done so many different kinds of things. And I'm curious if you've always had very strong curiosity about all kinds of music.

DM: Yeah. Certainly. When I was younger I started out in Gospel music. I remember the day I got my saxophone of Phil Hardymon, he came into the system, at the Berkeley, California school system. He is the one that handed me my alto. And he passed away a few years ago. A great trumpet player, Phil Hardymon. He is the one who is really responsible for bringing jazz into the Berkeley school system. And so that night I played the saxophone at church. I'm sure I was squeaking and sounding very strange, very much like I sound now but I had no idea what I was doing. My mother was playing piano, my brother on clarinet, my cousin playing trumpet, my father was playing guitar. I knew the songs but I didn't know the fingerings, but I was working on it. A few weeks later I blended right in. I had been playing bongos with them for like a couple of years already, but at nine, that was where I was. And I had taken piano lessons for two years already with a stride piano player that my mother put me with. And with me it was always, wherever I was, I felt comfortable there, but I also yearned to play other things. Like I strived to get out of church music in fact. Because we were the church band, we played every night, well three nights a week at least and all day Sunday. And after a while, you know, I'm a young man, I'm a teenager, I wanted to get out, I wanted to play gigs, I wanted to do different, I wanted to play blues gigs, so I'm starting to go out and do these kinds of things. I grew up in a very strict Church of God and Christ environment, where playing or practicing jazz in our house was forbidden. So I had to go out to my friends' places to practice and play that kind of music. After my mother passed away, when I was

and no mother. And he couldn't watch us all the time so I started bringing my things in the house and next thing I know my father got a little looser in terms of the Devil's music and what I could play at home. And I started playing, I even had the guys over for rehearsal. So that's how loose it became after my mother had passed away. So I always yearned to play other styles. So I'm playing R&B now, and also, I'm coming from Berkeley, California so in order to play gigs you have to know a large repertoire, also rock & roll. You have to know how to appease the people on the Berkeley campus, we're playing for a lot of parties and different things at UC Berkeley, things like that. So we played all of the rock material. The Grateful Dead was there, we played that stuff.

MR: This must have been late sixties.

DM: Yeah. This, we're talking like '68. '67, '68, '69. I'm 12, 13, and 14. And I'm 15 in 1970 when Jimi Hendrix died. So this is a very crucial period for me. In fact, I probably could describe myself as a hippie Black Panther on the political side and on the music side, psychedelic kind of a jazz, kind of a blues, kind of a bluegrass kind of guy.

MR: You've got it surrounded.

DM: Yeah. You know Berkeley is a hell of a place to grow up.

MR: I would think so.

DM: I mean I used to play guitar out on Telegraph Avenue and wish I was Jimi Hendrix, too. But that was another phase of me. And I'm in the middle of all of the riots at Berkeley, and all of the peace movements there, and all of the Black Panther things as well. So Berkeley is a hell of a place. It's right next to Oakland, but it's quite different.

MR: Yeah I spent, I was there last August just something at the college actually, and I can imagine that would have been a very fertile and stimulating environment.

DM: Well you know it's the only city that spoke up against the war in Afghanistan for instance, and they got a lot of flack from the rest of the United States. I mean this is the only city that stood out. In fact they wanted to bring harm to the city council because they were against the war. But Berkeley is a special place and I'm proud to have come from there. And one day I will go back there, because I think it's a paradise kind of a place and the thought process is very free.

MR: Let me just go back for a second to the connection between the church music and what you aspired to. It's interesting, what you were playing in the church had to be somewhat improvised, as far as your role.

DM: Of course. Me being like a single instrument, my role was to improvise, and to make it hot, and to phrase melodies when people — sometime when church people, they'll start off a song, and my mother was very good at this, they'd start a song off in about three different keys. They said [sings] I'm a soldier in the Army of the Lord. And somewhere

was very good at that, and to just nail it from the onset. She'd get the best of — the strongest tone they sang, she would make that the center. And I got good at it too after a while. And there was a lot of ear training going on there, because people, they come to church to sing and 99% of them can't sing at all, but they have a lot of enthusiasm.

MR: But the idea that you're playing improvised music but you can't play jazz. Your mother didn't like that. What was the distinction?

DM: Well as long as I was playing the church music and improvising it wasn't considered jazz. Like I mean I was getting into John Coltrane and Sonny Rollins and all these people, and I was putting that into the church. They didn't know I was really getting into that. All they knew was that as long as I could play the church melodies fine, whatever else I played, they didn't care. They didn't even know if it was jazz or not. They didn't care. But they knew that it was good. But they knew that when it came to playing that melody that I could play it strong. That was the point. So I got away with that I guess you could say. But that's where I learned to improvise, in the church. It's true.

MR: Did you retain the faith part of the church?

DM: Yes.

MR: Okay.

DM: Uh yes, I did. You know I've experimented with other religions, but you know it's like they say, you come right back to — a friend of mine in the World Saxophone Quartet, I'm not going to say who it is, but you know he was studying Indian religion, Ravi somebody, I can't remember. And we were in a small earthquake in Berkeley one time and he ran out in his underwear screaming, "Save me Jesus." So anyway, so I said, "Well what happened to the other religion thing?" He said, "Well I don't know." But the fact is, you know the way you're brought up is pretty much the way you're going to be, if it's put into you the way it was put into me. And that's my indoctrination. I could go and try to study different religions but when it comes down to it man, I'm going to go with what I know.

MR: Was there a time in your teens where you made a conscious decision that I'm going to try to be a professional musician?

DM: I had already, before I got in my teens, I had already determined that. That was already decided. When I seen Sonny Rollins play a solo saxophone at the Berkeley Jazz Festival when I was about 11, the next day I had to go get a tenor. I guess that would have been the moment. But I wanted to be a musician before that. But I wanted to be a tenor saxophone player after that. So that much I knew. So I asked my dad, I said, "I've got to get a tenor." So he took me to his credit union and we worked it out and I got a job and I paid for it, and I worked gigs to pay for it. And over a year's time I had a Mark VI. You

MR: What would you have been paid on a typical gig back then?

DM: Twenty-five dollars. If I made fifty that was great. But I mean hey, I was a kid. Sometimes we made more than that. But a gig was a gig. Fifty dollars when you're a kid is a lot of money.

MR: Indeed.

DM: So we would do that, and I played weekends all the way up in — I played weekends all the way up until I left college and came to New York. When I was at Pomona College I had a gig out on Foothill Boulevard, I went to Pomona College in Claremont. And I had a gig there during the weekends where I played, with the organ player, we played standards, and then there was a belly dancer there and I had a soprano then, and she liked the sound of it and so she told me just watch her navel and I just watched her navel and played. And I improvised and then I got paid twice, when I played at the Mirage, because of her. Because she was the middle act. And so I played on the beginning act and the middle act, and there was a third act. And then they repeated again. And that helped me. Music has always been a way to make a living also. That was also very important to me, that I make a living playing music. Because I've never done anything else. I never had a job, a real gig. And I thought it was important for me never to. I never wanted one. I mean I used to shine shoes and wash dishes when I was kid. I mean when I became in my later teens and an adult I never had a job other than music. I never wanted another job that wouldn't entail music.

MR: Did you get involved, even beyond the music, with the civil rights scene in Berkeley, and kind of social activism?

DM: Well in Berkeley, well there was a thing with Bobby Seale running for the mayor of Oakland and then the recall of D'Army Bailey. I participated on both of those as a student.

MR: I wasn't sure what you said — a recall of—

DM: Of D'Army Bailey. He was with the city council of Berkeley and he had gotten into a little trouble. He was involved with the Black Panthers and he had gotten involved with the police and they wanted to recall him from his position on the city council. So I was on that committee to help him. Anyway I guess I didn't get real political until I went to college. I think that's the time. Well although when I was very young, like 12 and no 13, when I was 13 was in '68, during the People's Park thing. I think Ronald Reagan was the governor. And they had a problem there with the county sheriff's because they were using buckshot. And they also had a problem because they dropped tear gas into the Willard Junior High School and I was the president of the student body there. Actually what happened was they missed People's Park from the helicopter. They misdiagnosed

towards Southgate. Willard was here, the People's Park is here, Southgate is there. So I guess they missed. And they dropped tear gas on 12 and 13-year-olds. And we had to turn the school out, and let it out. And of course all the students were angry. So we all went up and joined the mob. And we all were tear gassed already. So we started turning over cars. And so I don't know if that was political or just a reaction to the state throwing tear gas on some children. I don't know. You can call that political. I think that's just survival perhaps.

MR: How did your father feel about your being involved in those kinds of things, even though it wasn't a conscious choice, as you said, the circumstance kind of put you into it and you reacted.

DM: Well my father is from the school of — civil rights was very high on his list. Even being a staunch church man, we believed in Martin Luther King, and that was the same year that Martin Luther King was killed. So my father was for anything that had anything to do with making the situation better. I mean the fact that he moved to Berkeley and put us in a better neighborhood than our cousins who lived in Oakland — I remember one of the most angry times that I've ever seen him was when my brother moved into a ghetto in Oakland. He went over there and made him move out because he said you don't know how many sacrifices I had to make, being a garbageman and working extra jobs and doing this and that, for you to live in a city like Berkeley. So why in the hell would you go and live in a ghetto and put yourself at risk and now going to put my other brother at risk because he wants to live with you. I've never seen him so angry. So in his own way he was an activist. But not one that would join up with the Black Panthers or anything like that. But you know, just through the church you can express your anger. I think the church has been probably the strongest, I mean if you put it down for the year and years that they persevered, the church has been the strongest political animal in the black community, regardless of one speaker may raise up and be a communist or this or that, but the church has always been the overriding — it was always the place, even for them to hide if they needed sanctuary. The church would always take everybody back. And the church accepts everyone. The church, as far as acceptance, it's ecumenical, churches. It takes everyone. Our church, The Church of God and Christ accepts everyone. There's no lock in our churches. If a white man comes into our church we're going to take him. If he's down and out, come on in here and let's get you together. And if you want to go on your way, fine. If you want to stay you're welcome. That's what church is. And to me that's some activism right there, to me.

MR: Absolutely.

DM: Because sometimes, you know after Martin and Malcolm, you get all these opportunist

want to save the community, they want to be known for who they are. And they want to make themselves a leader. Most of the time a good leader just comes out of the people.

MR: And they have their own agenda for themselves.

DM: Yeah. I mean that's a good leader. And that's why Martin was so great because he just rose up through becoming a theologian to become who he was. I mean here's a man who made his father change his name because he became a great man. He became Martin Luther. He wasn't born Martin Luther, he was Melvin Lewis. And because he was a junior dad had to change his name too.

MR: I didn't know that.

DM: Yeah a lot of people don't. But the people in Atlanta know that.

MR: Yeah. Okay. Well let's talk about your progression as a musician a little bit. You had mentioned that to get into college you had to do some woodshedding with something that—

DM: James Newton. I had to do some woodshedding with James Newton to really get my flute chops together. Because I had a flute, I played it "Memphis Underground" or something, real light kind of flute stuff. Well I mean not light but, yeah light.

MR: Well you didn't have to have the greatest tone and all that.

DM: Yeah. I was no good on the flute. And I played piccolo in the marching band. I was no good. The tenor was my M.O. So anyway I had to work on a — anyway I knew all my scales and all that kind of stuff, but they just didn't sound the same on flute you know? So James, when I went down to Pomona to the black pre-freshman program, I got with James and I said, "Look, this is what I have to do for this audition." So we went through it, and okay, we'll work on a few things. We'll work on this Debussy thing and then we'll work on this Fauré. And it worked out really well. And I passed. And I was so happy. And so as soon as I got into Pomona, the first thing I did was I got the big band director fired somehow. Well the guy, we had a little money that they had saved up from the year before, and the guy decided that they wanted to invest it in some armbands for the big band. And some of those hats, the little straw hats.

MR: Oh my God.

DM: It's not that long ago, you know, this is '73 you know. But I was like, I said to the cats.

MR: Oh I'm sorry to interrupt you.

DM: The arm bands.

MR: Yeah, they're like garters almost.

DM: Yeah, they're like garters. So they wanted to go on this Dixie thing. And I was like oh man, I was the only guy that — well I was the only black guy that was in the stage band. So I said well look, I went to the director, Mr. Russell, to the head of the music

don't even know this guy, but I think that we need a real jazz guy if we're going to have a jazz stage band. So I suggested that he maybe should interview Bobby Bradford and John Carter. But John Carter was already teaching and so was Bobby, he was teaching at Pasadena CC and at another college. And John Carter was teaching at another college in Carver. So Bobby came in. He did an interview, and you know Bobby Bradford is great. He's a great educator. So Bobby got the gig. He just retired last year. And it got to be well known that people would come from other schools to be in that stage band after Bobby had really got the program on the road. So I was always happy that I was responsible for making the petition to get the other guy fired, to get Bobby in place, so that we could actually have jazz at Pomona College. And now they're proud of it. They're proud of the fact that they had jazz. That was the beginning of jazz at Pomona College.

MR: I see. Otherwise they were doing the Dixieland routine.

DM: We were going to die in there man. You know now, kids aren't going to go for that. Kids, they would never do that now, kids.

MR: You had mentioned transcribing solos and stuff, and how today there is so much more in the way of resources. Is it making a difference for young jazz musicians to have all those resources?

DM: Well I would say that there's so much information out here right now that I think the kids are bombarded with so much information. They have so much at their fingertips that sometimes they just don't know where to start. It used to be that you'd hear something come out, you'd immediately go to your record player, slow it down to 16-1/2, to be an octave down, and you'd transcribe it, then you've got a Trane solo. There it is. Or you've got a Sonny Rollins solo you know. And Bobby Bradford, when he told me, when Bird came out, those guys, and Fats Navarro, those cats. They would go, in Texas, they would go and do the same thing. Oh man we heard Bird did a solo man, everybody ran out, got the record and transcribed it, and so by the time Bird came their way all the cats knew his solo. They were singing his solo you know. They had it. I don't hear that kind of enthusiasm now, even though all those solos are already transcribed for everybody. So like sometimes when I do a class I say okay I want you guys to learn this solo up to this point. Give me six choruses. And it was like ahhhhh, do we got to? I say well you know, the fact is if we were back in those times, overnight this cat would have the solo. We'd have a solo. We might stay up all night to get that solo. And the whole thing was about memorizing the solo, not just playing the solo but memorizing the solo. These kids, they look in the book and play it, and then I say okay now play it without the book. Oh really? You want me to do that? Yeah. When I say play the solo, I mean play it by memory. Like

is. So then there's the other thing when you tell a kid to go study a song, they'll just get the head and then — the reason it's important to play the solo too is so you understand what the mechanics of the chord changes at a certain tempo, what they do. I mean that's the reason we learn solos anyway. But then we have to teach them to learn them, to forget them. That's how I teach. You learn the solo and get it in the head, you get them down. You maybe take twelve solos and learn all of them. But what you're learning is really the techniques inside the solo instead of that solo itself. So after you've learned them, a couple of years go by, then you forget them. But then you put that stuff in your back pocket. It's there. It'll come out when you need it. But don't, when you play on jam sessions and on gigs, it's not important to play these solos back. That's not the thing. And that's where some of the kids don't understand that if they go to New York and start playing at the jam sessions, if they play these solos back everybody's going to be bored to death. But what you need to do is develop your style out of what you learned in these solos. So I think as educators that's the thing that we have to teach them is to use these as little guidelines. Not verbatim.

MR: That step of trying to go from learning all that material and then forming your own sound seems to be a big thing in the jazz community. I know like, especially talking to real veteran guys in their seventies and eighties, and they'll listen to the current players. They seem to think that they're cookie cutter, they're all sounding the same.

DM: They are sounding the same. And I think I agree with them. I think the reason is because they've got so much information and they don't know how to — how do you say —

MR: Edit?

DM: Edit all this information inside. You know they have to be able to get all these things in order to have certain techniques but they have to use that to get to who they are. They have to go inside. What kids have to do, they have to start writing music themselves. They have to learn. When I came to New York, the way I learned, I had learned a lot of bebop and all that before I got to New York. And so when I got to New York I kept studying. I'm always — I study bebop even now, just to keep sharp, just to read something. You get up in the morning and go through the Omni book. When you go back to the Omni book it takes you days to go through it. Now it takes me an hour to go through it. It's like that. All those books are like that. You should be able to go through them in about 45 minutes after you do it every day. Then just throw it away for a while, just leave that one alone. You learn stuff to forget it. I don't know if that makes any sense, but jazz musicians say that all the time.

MR: You're keeping the concepts, but not the actual lines.

DM: Yeah. No, you don't want to be somebody. You want to be who you are. And I really

through, like I'll do a piece like "Morning Song" or something like that, or any song. And next thing I do an octet arrangement, the next thing I do a big band arrangement of the same song. And so in that I'm learning about music through my song, through my own song. I suggest to most kids that they should write their own music and then put it through a couple of different keys and really start to understand what their music can teach them about themselves. Then they're getting closer to finding out who they are. And in this process, playing your own stuff on the horn, playing for hours and hours of your own ideas, that's when you start to get up there when the Ornette Colemans and the Birds and the Sonny Rollinses and the Clifford Jordans and all these people, that kind of time that you spend just working out your own personal ideas. That's how you get a sound, by working like that. I mean like for instance I don't know if a lot of people know it but Ben Webster you know, I met an old girlfriend of Ben Webster and she used to always tell me she'd say you know when Ben was living up here in Sccandinavia he used to only practice on baritone. He wouldn't play the tenor until he came to the gig. There's ways. That would get you a sound.

MR: It's like running with weights on your feet.

DM: Yeah. And basketball players, they run around with these weight vest things and they take them off and they're gone you know. I mean there's ways to get to yourself. And you've got to use everything that's there. You can't just think you can just get a concept out of a book. That's somebody else's concept, that's not yours. You've got to work hard to develop. And I think the whole thing with conceptualizing who you want to be, seeing yourself in the future, seeing a composition, writing a composition like all these great composers, it takes time and it takes a lot of thinking power to envision something that's not completed, something way down the road, to write a piece for a year and figure out what that is. After that year is up, you've seen the end before, but in the middle of that process you learned a lot about you. You have to force yourself to make these projects happen for yourself. I do that all the time. I put limitations on myself and I always have a goal too, as far as what I want to accomplish. Like the last thing that I did was I went to Cuba, this was the third time I recorded in Cuba. The first time I recorded a Cuban big band, some Cuban cats and I brought a few Americans. The second time I recorded a string album in Cuba, and I used ten Cuban string players but the music has nothing to do with Cuba, it was jazz, I just used the string players because I found that the Cuban string players had a little bit more rhythm when it came to executing my parts, my string parts. And this last recording, I used some people from Guadeloupe and I took them to Cuba and recorded in Cuba, and I used Cuban horn players but not to solo, only to play my lines. So that's a project. And then I put Pharoah Sanders on it the other day, as a guest

something that I've seen, last year, and I've been writing little lines, and then when I got down to Cuba it all came together to me, okay, I've had this band together four years, it's called the Gwo-Ka Masters. The Gwo-Ka means the kwa drum from Guadeloupe, that's the drum that they had on the slave ships and they had a little tent around the side and when they got to Guadeloupe and the slaves, they seen all these drum barrels, they put a skin on it and it became their drums, the kwa drums, and they named their music after it. So it was the Gwo-Ka Masters, because it's Guadeloupe. So I envisioned putting that concept of the machte and the boula drum, which is tuned by your bare foot hitting on the skin while you play it, and the other one you play upright. Putting that with jazz, putting that with my kind of jazz, putting that with my octet version of what I do, so now I'm calling it the Gwotet, which means nothing to anybody but me. But this is my world. This is all my world. And nobody cares about it but me. But when it comes out and they hear that, they say woah, what a concept. But for me that was a work in progress, and it still is. It's just growing in my mind. I'm trying to figure out how to incorporate jazz into, and then there's the singing on top which is in Creole, which is something that we might not understand here, but they understand it in New Orleans, it's the French Creole. It's a version, you know most people from Guadeloupe are from Guinea, so you hear this accent. It's African and then it's partly Caribbean too. And then it's me, so it's American, it's jazz, it's these different things. To me that's what's interesting about jazz right now is that I can use my influence to do anything I want.

MR: Your influence musically or your—

DM: Well my expertise — whatever expertise that I've developed in jazz, me personally, I could take that and use Ornette Coleman's concept and James Blood Ulmer, they say jazz is the teacher and Funk is the preacher. So in other words when you say "funk" you mean, I think they mean that you have to include the young, and that's the way to bring in the young, because the guy whose got the vocal box is the one — it's like rap. You know eventually jazz and rap have to get a little closer together than it is even now, because that's what the kids are listening to. And if people want an audience in the next hundred years, you're going to have to do something besides play with your quartet to bring that on. So I feel like I'm doing that now. I'm trying to bring other people in. Because jazz is such a free music that it includes everybody. And everybody seems like they could put their two cents in. So I'm putting mine in too. But jazz is a teacher, and every other music is the preacher to whoever their constituents are.

MR: How much of what you do when you decide on a project is driven by economic realities? Does that stop you?

DM: Oh God. Oh yeah man. Because I'm always having to deal with that. Like for instance

about doing something with two choirs and a big band. Okay. Well how about like two singers and eight guys in the band? You know, I mean, well that's knocked down. Every day. Like right now I was invited to Seattle to play at a concert with my Latin big band. And they only want to pay a fee, they'll pay the transportation but not from Cuba. There's problems with Cuba anyway. Okay I was going to get some Latin cats from New York. That's even impossible. So now I have to re-write the music so that it actually is octet.

MR: Oh. For that one gig.

DM: For that one gig. So now I've got arrange an album's worth of music to play at this festival, and either truncate what I've done with the big band and make it smaller — I mean you can't use the same music, it's going to sound like crap you know. Any arranger knows that. You just have to do it over again. Otherwise it's not going to sound — so that's work. That's serious work. To me that's two weeks of work right there, just for this one gig. And to this booker, they just say well it's a gig. I say yeah, but you know, you've got to get me more for that. That's like the Nice Jazz Festival, they wanted to give me some money to do, they wanted me to re-write "Porgy & Bess." And it was like the money was sizeable, I mean it was like $25,000. And I looked at my schedule and finally I said no. Because for me to change — I mean that would like change my life for the next six months, for me to re-write "Porgy & Bess."

MR: You'd have to stop—

DM: For one gig, man. I couldn't do it. I had to say no, I can't. Because I mean I'm not going to just — if I'm going to do it, I'm going to do it. I'm not going to do it half ass. Because then I'd have a bad reputation for that. So that's the first time I said no. No, I can't do it. You've got to get the next guy.

MR: The nature of the business seems to be that everybody's got multiple projects. I can imagine how hard it must be to get the people you want for either recording, or to do those concerts.

DM: Yeah. Well you know what I've done is I have a nucleus and my nucleus is my quartet. Hamid Drake and Jaribu Shahid, as a trio. I mean those two guys are pretty much my nucleus in everything that I'm doing right now. So when the rhythm section is strong, you seem like you could build anything around it. It's like you've got your motor and you've got your steering wheel and you've got — all you needs is some seats and a chassis. And then the ornaments and horns and brake lights you can put around it.

MR: That's a good analogy.

DM: Yeah.

MR: Let me play — we had talked about this particular song, in the eighties.

MR: Can you tell me where this particular song came from, or do you get your inspiration from any particular place?

DM: I call that song "Morning Song" because it was a song that I heard my mother play. My father was a garbageman. And a lot of nights he would kneel down to pray, he'd go to bed fairly late to be getting up at 5:00. Sometimes I'd see him on his knees, I'd go to the bathroom late at night and he would actually be asleep in the middle of his prayers. And then it's 5:00 and I know he had to get up right off his knees and go to work. And my mother would get up and try to get him out of the house, and as soon as she got him out of the house that was her quiet time, and this was the time that she would practice. And this is what I heard in this time. That's why I call it "Morning Song." Because it's the music that I heard in the morning. Every morning I heard this.

MR: That's a great story.

DM: And it sounds like even the same song or something. It was like a recurring thing she used to do, and to me it sounds like that. And she would sing too.

MR: It's got a couple of sections to it. It goes into a swing thing eventually.

DM: It takes everybody out because it's like 16-17-16, that's the form.

MR: Oh. There's no coasting on it.

DM: Oh no, no. That 17th bar will get you if you're not on it. And then there's a one-two bar. [scats]. That part [scats] that's a one-two [scats].

MR: Did you do that because you had a melody going and you needed to put it in let's call it an odd measure to accommodate the melody?

DM: Yeah. Because to me, the melody is the strongest thing. I mean I think I write strong melodies because I concentrate on the melodies. Melodies are what makes a song. I mean you could have chords going but the chords — I prefer to write a melody before I write the structure. It dictates the structure, as far as I'm concerned. Because in the end it's the melody that the people are going to be whistling walking down the street. And a lot of people have told me that they wake up in the middle of the night whistling some of my songs. If I didn't write in that way, I don't know if they would whistle somebody's rhythms. Something about melody, it changes you.

MR: That's a great compliment I think when people say, "You know that tune you wrote, I just got it in my head."

DM: Yeah. Can't get it out. I think that's great. And you know emotion is something too, speaking about compliments, the biggest compliment that I ever had was a did a string concert one time at the Public Theater in New York. And I took the opportunity to — I did all ballads. It was me with strings, but it was all ballads. So like a couple of years after that I'm walking down St. Mark's Place, a couple comes up to me and they say,

highest — I was exalted. That was it. They knighted me right there. I'm still going from that.

MR: That's great.

DM: So you know, if that human being came out of my string ballad concert — I mean there were actually people weeping in the concert. There's something about strings that can make you go into it. But the whole thing is to do it without being maudlin. It can be contrived. You know strings, you can be cornball city with strings too, especially if you approach it from the ballad thing. Anyway, and that's the whole thing about melody and song form, there's a battle in the society right now because everybody's more conditioned to hear beats. And the song form is getting a licking right now. When a guy like Stevie Wonder can't come up with a hit, you know he's a real songwriter. I mean I'm speaking in the black community particularly right now. When the community is like hoodwinked into thinking that this is only music. These beats, and this rap. This is what we call music now and this other stuff is maudlin and contrived because it is a melody. It sounds like, to them, somebody's in a theater and then all of a sudden they break into song. And it's corny. No it's not corny. It's a song. Songs will always be back. But it's not here right now. And I think, I'm waiting for the time when the songwriter in the community will raise his head again.

MR: I look forward to that too. Yeah. It's interesting when you think about what are the songs — I occasionally play like weddings and stuff. And people seem to be, even young people now, gravitating toward the older songs, because what can they pick that's current to play at a function like that.

DM: Yeah. Yeah exactly. Like when you play at weddings these days, I mean I haven't played at weddings but I've got two sisters that are getting married and they're going to always play "I Will Always Love You" and these kind of songs. But those songs are old now. They're not current stuff. I mean like what do you do? What are you going to do, a rap? [raps] I love you baby 'cause — you know. And even the rappers, they tried the whole thing with dealing with songs from the eighties and putting it with the rap. Now they're writing these real little short, not songs even, they're like hooks. They do the rap and then they put these little hooks in it, these little hooks inside. I love you baby [scats] then the guy starts rapping, then they go back and forth. But it's not really a song, it's just like an eight bar or four bar phrase of a song. So I think they're moving towards getting back to songwriting, and this young kid Pharell is starting to – the guy that's got the number one hit, I seen him Saturday night in Central Park. And this guy, Pharell, with the NERD, he's beginning to do that. He's starting to bring the song form back in to the rap. And that was the point in his concert the other night, that I almost wanted to hear rap. I was like

actually singing songs. I mean he was singing like in a smoky style, but it was against, almost like he had a band that wasn't really a jazz band, it wasn't a soul band, it was more like a rock band, the NERD. So anyway kids like him I think are the brighter kids that are doing music. And my son is into making beats and into writing songs. He just did a wonderful — he did some beats and kind of like, used like a musicscape of like Skies of America, Ornette Coleman. And he's trying to — he wants to be a producer. So this is a kid I'm talking about maybe trying to get up here. Because when he comes up here he'll light the place up too. Because he's quite a brilliant kid. But the future is in these kids that want to learn how to be musicians see. Ten years ago I would hear rappers get on the radio and say, "Well you know these days we don't have to be musicians." And they were bragging the fact, this as a fact. I said boy these guys, they sound so ignorant that I don't even want to listen to them rap anymore. If that's the way he speaks. But that's the future. And I'm not going to rule the rappers out because it's been around for a long time, but I'm just thinking it's time for them to learn some music and I think Pharell and some of these young kids are — funk will move it on out.

MR: I wanted to briefly just ask you about your experience with the Grateful Dead.

DM: Oh well, you know, God, first of all Bob Weir is really a good friend of mine. And the way we met was through Michael Nash and Carrie Williams. They asked me to be part of this — of writing the music for a musical about Satchel Paige. And so we began to collaborate, Taj Mahal, Bob Weir and myself, Michael Nash and Carrie were writing the libretto. And it's been a process now that's been going on for seven years you know. And I think — we've had several workshops, we had Avery Brooks come in and direct us, we've had several directors coming in to do workshops. And I think maybe approaching ten years, it's going to eventually be out there on Broadway. We have 35 songs, and what we've realized ourselves, it's pretty good songwriting. I think the music is far ahead of the script. And they're doing revisions of the script. And this brought me into the idea of like them saying well hey David, we're playing at Madison Square Garden, why don't you come and sit in. Well all right, I'll sit in, I'll be down. So I come and sit in. Bamm it's like twenty thousand people there. And I'd never seen such an attentive audience. I mean I play, I've played the Vanguard and this jazz club and that, the Blue Note and all this, there's always somebody talking at the bar that I can hear, usually a musician you know. And I play, I say waaa on my sax and I see all the heads. Wow. They're with me the whole time. What a wonderful audience these guys have developed. And I was just thinking man, I wish we had such a dedicated crew, especially twenty thousand of them you know. So then I go sit in with them out in San Francisco. Same thing. And then I played one other time with them. And I played with Jerry Garcia's band, I sat in with him

Then he dies, right in the middle of his time, and it's just incredible that, I mean I never got paid a dime to play with them but what I did get was all this recognition from all these people. Every time I played a concert, somebody would come in with a shirt like this and say, "Play one for Jerry, Dave." You know, I'm like okay. And so then I did an album of their music. Because they were really such nice people. I was like well hey let me take your music and put it in a jazz thing, let's put this together and let me put this with my octet and see what that would do. And it was a very successful album. People loved it. And after that I was like in their camp. So now the Dead is back together, Phil Lesh just got a new liver, they're back in it man. Kreutzmann came back and Billy Hart, he's back, and they had to have Kreutzmann because Billy, he could play a lot of things but time is not one of them. But now they've got Billy to play the time so now they're really back. Because he had really retired. So that's why they're back, because Billy came back. And God bless them. I love those guys. I mean and the thing is, I went in a bookstore and they have all of these new books about Jerry Garcia. I counted like fourteen of them. And I'm on like several pages of every one of them, just because of those few situations that I just spoke of. And so it's like a cult thing man. I will always be connected with these people. And we're talking about doing some stuff now.

MR: That's great. You seem to have the most wide open ears I can imagine. Even—

DM: Berkeley man. It really is Berkeley man. I don't have any control over that. And I think it's just the way I grew up. I couldn't be any other way. Right now I'm trying to hear stuff, like being in Paris, I hear all kinds of stuff. There's a 24-year-old guitar player that's from Senegal, his name is Herve Samb. And his mother is Vietnamese. And he's a mixed kid. This kid, I think if there's another Jimi, he's going to be it. I've never seen anybody like that. So there's people all over the world man, if you could see them. I just tell the guys, I says I'm going to make sure you always owe me money. Because one day they're going to give you some. Because this kid is incredible. So he comes out on the road and he never wants to spend his money, so I always say like okay, but I always keep a tab on him. I just always want to make sure that you always owe me money. Because they're going to give you a bunch of it one day. I hope you take care of it.

MR: That's good. Good to have those kind of people in your back pocket.

DM: Yeah but I'm trying to collect these people all over the world. It's like, it's not in New York where you find everybody. There's other places where you find people like, it's one of a kind. There's a few people like that on this planet. And I'm trying to assemble them. That's kind of what I'm trying to do. There's some talents down in Cuba man, that is untouched, untapped. There's a few great people, great bands, that people haven't even heard. Like this guy Manolito Simonet, he's great. This guy's got like a number two hit

MR: I'm not sure if I can phrase this question but I'll try. If I was to take a solo of yours and transcribe it, and then match what you're playing against the chord structure and try to justify everything you're playing by saying "notice how David took the tritone substitution," and all that, would that be legitimate or are some of the things you do happy accidents?

DM: Happy accidents. That's a good way to put it. Well let's put it like this. I remember when they came out with my first transcription of — I had recorded "Body and Soul." And I remember coming home and putting it next to Coleman Hawkins, putting it next to, bar by bar, next to Coleman Hawkins' solo and playing through mine, playing through his, playing through mine, playing through his. And then I realized that what I was doing, I mean on a solo like that you could, because in that particular solo I was pretty much playing in a more traditional kind of way. It would depend on which solo you transcribe. If it was a song where I just took off, then I'm not sure that the chord changes, at one point, sometimes when I'm playing sometimes the chord changes becomes more like, not necessarily that I'm not following the chord changes because I am, but I'm playing across the chord changes through the harmonic series. That would probably be very difficult to transcribe and be accurate as far as what I'm thinking when I'm playing. Now a happy accident — mmm — I'm not sure an accident would describe it. Because I always know where I am now. Maybe other people might not think I know where I am, but I'm always — when I'm playing with songs that have chords I'm very aware of the chord structure. I'm challenging that structure is what I'm trying to do. I'm trying to defy it. I'm trying very hard to defy it and dispel it at the same time that I'm playing it. Perhaps it sounds like an accident because I'm covering some new ground on it. And usually I would have probably played that song so many times before it got to that recording that I'm playing across that song like I own that song. That song, and it probably is mine anyway. So I feel like well I can do anything with my own song that I want to. And this is how I want the final result to sound like. So be it somebody else's idea of an accident or a train wreck or whatever, fine, if you want to call it that, that's cool. But that's exactly what I was trying to get to, otherwise I wouldn't have let it out. I mean I wouldn't have let that version come out. So that's pretty much the way I see it. I feel like what I'm trying to do as a soloist is to stretch the boundaries. Because to me everybody that comes to New York, each person that comes in, each soloist comes in, they set the bar a little higher and they challenge people to think a different way. And that's kind of what I'm trying to do. I'm trying to let people think a different way about how they could approach even playing chord changes.

MR: That's a great answer. I like the way you described it.

MR: Well what's in the near future for you? I know you're mixing another album.

DM: Well the near future is to mix this album. I'm playing Carnegie Hall on the fourteenth with my quartet with strings so I'm using ten — this time I'm using ten string players from New York. I hope they execute as well as the Cubans. I'm going to do this gig in Seattle I have to waste my time on doing. I probably will do a recording with Taj Mahal and Ishmael Reed, another Gwo-Ka with Kip Hanrahan. I think that's on the books for October. November and December I'll just probably be doing some gigs with the Gwo-Ka Masters. This little period of time right in here I'm concentrating on getting my kid in to a decent college. We'll see, maybe he'll wind up here.

MR: Maybe so. We'd be happy to have him. Well it's been fascinating talking to you and having you on campus.

DM: Oh I'm looking forward to playing the concert.

MR: You are a very creative man.

DM: Well this is a great place to be. I'm happy to have done this interview with you. Thank you.

MR: All right.

DM: I'll look forward to the dinner tonight. Thank you.